



Praveen.

Last month, all I-League clubs wrote to the AIFF requesting a reduction in Club Licensing fines so they can survive in the long run.

"These fines, as we have raised in multiple individual and joint discussions with you, are excessive and, in many cases, unjust, given the financial and operational constraints under which I-League clubs operate," read the letter.

Sportstar understands that

I-League clubs were fined around ₹2 crore for licensing breaches.

"I feel the biggest losers have been the club owners. At the end of the day, they're spending from their own pockets but not getting even the same returns they did four years ago," Anuj adds.

Issues down the order

Further down the structural pyramid, in I-League 2, similar challenges persist. The AIFF's budget

All smiles: Diamond Harbour got promoted to I-League after its I-League 2 title win in 2024-25. AIFF MEDIA

allocation for the league has fallen by over 55 per cent in just three years.

"Limited visibility, inconsistent refereeing standards, infrastructure gaps, and constrained revenue opportunities are all significant hurdles," says Gaurav Manchanda, owner of I-League 2 side FC Bengaluru United (FCBU), established in 2018.

Anuj added that the lack of sponsors and prize money makes the league an uphill battle.

"Last year, we played I-League 2 in a home-and-away format. So, the logistics cost was at least ₹40 to ₹50 lakh," he says. "But we hardly received any money from it. If you finish in the top four of the I-League, you get some prize money. We finished third in I-League 2 last season, but got nothing."

Yet, there are positives to the league. Over the past two seasons, 57 clubs across 23 states have participated in the I-League, I-League 2 and I-League 3, making it a truly pan-India competition.

"The good thing about I-League 2 is that no foreigners are allowed," says Anuj, while Manchanda adds, "The shift from the traditional group stage format to the current qualifier league format has brought much-needed stability and consistency to I-League 2."

Clubs now get a guaranteed 14 games over two to four months, which improves squad planning, financial security, and makes the league more meaningful.

The Indian football pyramid is in disarray, starting from the top-flight. But if the layers below continue to erode, will the topsoil really remain? The AIFF will need to put a lot of thought into that before it's too late.

Pall of gloom: Chennai City FC is one of the eight I-League clubs to have shut down since 2014. NISSAR AHMAD

